Comparative Evaluation of English Translations of Ancient Tamil Literature

1. Original Source

Source: *Purananuru*, Poem 192 — “Yaadhum Oore, Yaavarum Kelir”

Author: Kaniyan Pungundranar

Period: Sangam period (exact date unknown)

Original language: Tamil

யாதும் ஊரே யாவரும் கேளிர்
தீதும் நன்றும் பிறர்தர வாரா

Source: Original poem

2. Translations

Translation A — G. U. Pope:
“To us all towns are one, all men our kin. / Life’s good comes not from others’ gifts, nor ill.”

Translation B — A. K. Ramanujan:
“Every town our home town, / every man a kinsman. / Good and evil do not come from others.”

Reference for translation discussion: Literary discussion

3. Differences Between Both Translations

Lexical similarity — Jaccard similarity: Approximately 0.18 (18%), based on normalized unique-word sets. The translations share relatively few exact words.

Semantic similarity: High by qualitative assessment. Both express universal human kinship and the idea that good and evil do not originate from others.

Key difference: Translation A uses more traditional poetic language, while Translation B communicates the ideas more directly. Low lexical similarity does not necessarily indicate low semantic similarity.

4. Evaluation Rubric

Criterion	What is evaluated
Accuracy / Fidelity	Preservation of the original meaning, key ideas and nuances.
Fluency / Naturalness	Grammar, idiomatic wording, readability and poetic flow.
Cultural Context	Preservation of cultural values, philosophical ideas and literary tone.

How naturalness is measured: Independent evaluators can rate grammar, idiomatic word choice, readability and poetic flow on a five-point scale, from very poor to excellent. The average rating can be normalized to the rubric scale. This makes the judgment more transparent and repeatable.

The scores below are provisional judgments, not results from an actual multi-evaluator study.

5. Evaluation of the Two Translations

Translation A — G. U. Pope

• Accuracy / Fidelity: 3.5/4
• Fluency / Naturalness: 2.5/3
• Cultural Context: 2.5/3
Comment: The main message is preserved, but “others’ gifts” slightly changes the nuance, and some wording feels old-fashioned.

Translation B — A. K. Ramanujan

• Accuracy / Fidelity: 4/4
• Fluency / Naturalness: 2.75/3
• Cultural Context: 2.75/3
Comment: The meaning is expressed directly and clearly. “Kinsman” retains the idea of kinship but sounds somewhat archaic in modern English.

6. Additional Evaluation Metrics

Metric	Purpose
Jaccard Similarity	Measures overlap between unique words.
BLEU	Measures matching word sequences against a reference translation.
BERTScore	Compares contextual word representations to assess semantic similarity.
Human Naturalness Rating	Evaluates fluency and readability using a defined scale.
Inter-rater Agreement	Checks consistency between multiple human evaluators.

Note: Only the Jaccard score is numerically calculated here. BLEU, BERTScore and inter-rater agreement require additional computation or evaluator data.

7. Conclusion

This comparison shows that translation quality cannot be judged only by word overlap. Although the translations have low lexical similarity, both preserve the central message of universal kinship. Translation B communicates the meaning more directly. Combining lexical metrics, semantic evaluation and a clearly defined human-scoring rubric offers a more informative approach to evaluating ancient Tamil literature.

References

• Original poem: oldtamilpoetry.com
• Translation discussion: ResearchGate
• BLEU: Papineni et al., 2002
• BERTScore: Zhang et al., 2020
• COMET: Rei et al., 2020
• MQM framework: The MQM Initiative